



It's about (damn) time: Community, temporality, and feminist values in activist public relations history

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ABSTRACT

Community activism provides a useful lens for reexamining core concepts of public relations theory and history: community, temporality, and feminist values. This project foregrounds the work of two transformative community activists and prolific authors, Grace Lee Boggs and bell hooks—women whose decades-long efforts balanced urgency and sustained commitment to issues, as well as the people in the neighborhoods and physical communities they were a part of. While temporal concerns have found a place in crisis communication scholarship (e.g., Bean & Madden, 2019; Bean et al., 2015; Liu et al., 2017), they have yet to be presented as a central part of theories of activism in public relations. Adding their voices and perspectives to the broader story of public relations history helps to (1) center non-corporate histories as public relations, (2) showcase stories and strategies of women of color as effective advocates and transformative community leaders, and (3) present temporally informed theoretical development in activist public relations, including the creation of a new framework: ongoing community activism.

Public relations history has tended to prioritize corporate communication practices and showcase professional, self-identified practitioners over activists and other genres of the discipline (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2012b; Fitch & L'Etang, 2017; Lamme & Russell, 2009; Russell & Lamme, 2016). This conceptual essay centers two feminist community activists, Grace Lee Boggs and bell hooks, to both integrate their actions into public relations history as well as to drive theoretical development around community, temporality, and feminist values in activist public relations. While activism and social movements are often grounded in communities and deeply connected to physical place, only a few studies in public relations have focused on community-centered activism (e.g., Capizzo & Madden, 2022; Doan & Toledano, 2018; Madden & Pevac, 2023; Moscato, 2018; Weaver, 2010). In relation to the immediacy of many stakeholder- or publics-oriented outcomes in public relations—such as stakeholder prioritization (Rawlins, 2006), the situational theory of publics (Plowman et al., 2015), or intersectional digital activism (Vardeman & Sebesta, 2020)—community activism provides an analytic lens open to significant temporal variability. For example, neighborhood-level community building for social change may be a decades-long endeavor (Baker, 2018; Boggs, 2011, 2016; hooks, 2003, 2009). Community activism is a powerful example of how public

relations strategies and tactics can help organizations better understand their potential for social change (Holtzhausen, 2000). It may also help answer the call for deeper understandings of the long-term implications of organizational actions (Kent, 2011; O'Neil, 2009). Finally, feminist values (e.g., Aldoory & Toth, 2021; Golombisky, 2015; Grunig et al., 2000) and feminist activism (e.g., Gudkova & Sarikakis, 2018; Madden et al., 2018; Weaver, 2013) reflect a crucial connection to a community's social injustices and inequities as the foundation for advocacy. Taken together, geographic community, feminist values, and conscious temporality (particularly long-term relational perspectives) provide a novel lens through which we can more clearly understand the value of ongoing community activism as part of public relations.

The purpose of this essay is to examine the sustained, feminist community activism of Boggs and hooks to inform and augment activist theory in public relations, as well as to identify their contributions as part of activist public relations history. To do so, it will provide a grounding in relevant public relations literature (activist history, community activism, temporality, and feminist theory), and an in-depth excavation of the writing and activism of Boggs and hooks—two activists that devoted their careers to inspiring their communities to engage in social change. Finally, we present the new framework of *ongoing*

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community activism, which incorporates feminist values and temporality into community activism in public relations theory. Community activism reflects temporal extremes of immediate social need and generational societal commitment—contributing to scholarship on activist and community-oriented public relations’ ability to build social capital (e.g., Edwards, 2016; Taylor, 2010, 2018; Saffer, 2016; Yang & Taylor, 2015) and strengthen communities (e.g., Dharmasena et al., 2020; Hallahan, 2004; Moscato, 2018; Shen & Jiang, 2022; Stoker & Stoker, 2012). A more inclusive understanding of public relations history—by centering both non-corporate practices and women of color—provides a more complete picture of what public relations can be, as well as contributes to a fuller articulation of its potential for social change and community benefit.

1. Literature review

1.1. Activist public relations history

Much of the traditional textbook-based history of public relations revolves around “heroes and founders” such as P.T. Barnum, Edward Bernays, Ivy Lee, and Arthur Page, all of whom used their skills and expertise primarily to promote businesses (Myers, 2020, p. 6). While recent scholarship has yielded a more holistic and critical look at the origins and growth of public relations, Fitch and L’Etang (2017) note that, “of the available histories, many rely on practitioner perspectives and are often written for textbooks; they tend to offer widely accepted but uncritical accounts focused on professional achievements” (p. 118). Additionally, these histories provide an overrepresentation of white men, excluding women and people of color who have made significant contributions to public relations’ development (Pompper & Ertem-Eray, 2021). Rather than narrowing an understanding of public relations history to those figures who self-identify as public relations practitioners, we follow Russell and Lamme’s (2016) understanding that the discipline’s history needs only be limited in that “a person, campaign or program should have high strategic intent and the intended public must have a high level of agency” (p. 746), in that the bounds of this definition of public relations extend up to, for example, societies without genuine freedom of speech, association, or action or in situations where citizen action is compelled or coerced rather than based in persuasion. Broadening the historical lens with which we see public relations allows for a more critical view toward certain practices (such as propaganda) as well as a wider range of practices, including the ability to center activists and activism (L’Etang, 2014). A richer and more complete history of public relations incorporates activist organizations (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2012b; Madden et al., 2018; Olasky, 1985; Smith & Ferguson, 2010; Sommerfeldt et al., 2012), social movements (e.g., Doerfel and Taylor, 2017; Edrington & Lee, 2018; Hill, 2016; Hon, 1997; Reyes, 2018; Vardeman & Sebesta, 2020), and practitioners as activists within organizations (Holtzhausen, 2000, 2013; Holtzhausen & Voto, 2002). Centering activism provides a reminder that public relations can be used for societally positive ends (i.e., Edwards, 2016; Williams & Sommerfeldt, 2021), highlights distinct and potentially innovative tactics (Der-ville, 2005; Sommerfeldt & Xu, 2014), and reminds scholars and practitioners that nonprofit and activist communication is just as much a part of the practice as corporate communication (e.g., Grunig, 1992; Woods, 2019). As Ciszek (2015) notes:

Activism and public relations are not in separate camps but occupy a fluid environment informed by cultural-economic forces. Conceptualizing activism as outside of public relations or the enemy of public relations misses the mark. The identities of activism and public relations are fluid, multiple, conflicting, and at times overlapping. (p. 453)

That said, pure conflation of corporate and activist public relations may, worryingly, serve to launder the reputation of corporate public relations if it does not fully articulate the context and distinctions of

activist approaches (Weaver, 2018). Corporate co-optation of historically activist public relations tactics has continued to blur these distinctions (Coombs & Holladay, 2012a).

Activist organizations have distinct goals and objectives from corporations (Jacques, 2006; Sommerfeldt, 2013b), but they include a wide variety of structures and purposes. For example, social movement organizations (i.e., Hon, 1997; McCarthy & Zald, 1977) often reflect relatively formal, traditional, and hierarchical organizational structures, while connective action organizations operate with less structure and looser networks that are more often digitally driven (Bennett & Segerberg, 2012). Within these networks of activism, public relations practitioners and those utilizing the strategies and tactics of public relations in service of activist organizations and social movements may utilize a variety of approaches depending on the nature of the organization, the makeup of the network, and the relevant goals and objectives (Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2017). As Holtzhausen (2007) noted, “activists lose their typical activist attributes as they become institutionalized” (p. 369)—rather than an activist/corporate binary, this reflects a continuum of strategies and tactics with degrees of distinction between a traditional corporate approach and an activist approach.

1.2. Community activism in public relations

Scholarship in public relations around the concept of *community* has remained an important and enduring stream of research (e.g., Hallahan, 2004; Kruckeberg & Starck, 1988; Valentini et al., 2012). Public relations as a profession and an organizational function includes responsibilities to societies and communities above the interests to individual organizations or clients (e.g., Holtzhausen, 2000; Holtzhausen & Voto, 2002; Stoker & Stoker, 2012). Thus, building community ties and connections can serve as significant and beneficial outcomes (as well as a central purpose) of public relations, as demonstrated in scholarship on social capital (e.g., Saffer, 2019; Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010, 2011, 2018)). Thus, activism and activist public relations can, through building social capital, generate social change (You & Hon, 2019).

Beyond an issue-centered advocacy context, the community building aspects of nonprofit and activist public relations have been an understudied and undertheorized area of scholarship, but recent work has fostered increased interest (e.g., Capizzo & Madden, 2022; Madden & Alt, 2021; Moscato, 2018; Pompper, 2020; Shen & Jiang, 2022; Vujnovic et al., 2021; Witherow, 2020). Kruckeberg and Starck (1988) first explored the community building imperative for public relations theory, emphasizing the need for organizations to understand their community responsibilities and fulfill their potential to contribute. Building on the work of John Dewey, this approach emphasized geographic place as central to its understanding of community (Vujnovic et al., 2021). Similarly, Hallahan (2004) presents *community building* as a crucial societal value of public relations: “Community building cogently summarizes what many practitioners envision that public relations ought to be—a proactive (nonreactive) effort to bring people together through involvement, nurturing, and organizing” (p. 250). These three facets (involvement, nurturing, and organizing) reflect the potential concrete contributions of a public relations function or mindset to any organization—whether that is strengthening a community-oriented corporate CSR program or supporting a community activist group in achieving its goals. While Kruckeberg and Tsetsura (2008) critiqued the limitations of geographic place for community—and multiple scholars have emphasized the disembedding of community and identity from place (i.e., Falkheimer, 2018; Witmer, 2006)—this project utilizes community activism to refocus on physical place as a central aspect of community. Cities and communities can be central sites of activist communication and productive contestation (Moscato, 2018). More critically, Vujnovic and colleagues (2021) note that a community building mindset forces public relations to center localized community needs and aspirations, often rejecting external, globalized ideas of progress.

1.3. Temporality in public relations

Temporality or the human experience of time and timing has the potential to be a generative area of public relations scholarship, particularly in contexts of activism. Recent research has explored several topical areas including alerts and warnings in crises or emergencies (Bean & Madden, 2019; Bean et al., 2015; Liu et al., 2017; Madden, 2015), dialogue and propinquity or timely engagement (e.g., Capizzo, 2018; Kent & Taylor, 2002; Madden & Alt, 2021; Taylor & Kent, 2014), and short-term activism (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2012a; Pal & Dutta, 2008). Less explicitly, temporality undergirds our assumptions of several central public relations theories, including the situational theory of publics/situational theory of problem solving (e.g., Kim & Ni, 2010) and issues management (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2018; Madden, 2019; McKasy & Zulli, 2021; Waymer & Heath, 2019), which is grounded on the cyclical nature of issues in democratic society. Digital technology has led to a time compression phenomenon, in some cases accelerating activism and social movements (e.g., Poell, 2020; Pal & Dutta, 2008) as well as increasing “temporal expectations” among organizational stakeholders in need of timely information for their safety and security (Madden, 2015, p. 190). It has also been theorized in significantly longer timeframes, including Kent’s (2011) integration of the *long now* into public relations theory, or—most relevant to this project—the role of ongoing or decades-long activist projects, such as Ciszek and colleagues’ (2021) examination of discursive stickiness in the American Psychiatric Association’s periodic revisions of “disorders” around gender identity in its Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM) from the 1950 s to the present. These multiple contexts present a common dual temporal concern for many activists: (1) Immediate injustice or grievance that deserves attention and resolution as well as (2) ongoing, long-term commitments to ensure the values of social justice are enacted, maintained, and expanded over time (McLean et al., 2021). Poell (2020) explains that the immediacy of digital protest (along with an ever-shortening news cycle) has made it increasingly difficult for social movement activists to maintain public awareness or concern beyond fleeting, episodic moments of action. This has complicated the legitimacy-building process and, in some cases, made it more difficult to build momentum toward formal changes as part of elections and public policy (Coombs & Holladay, 2018).

1.4. Feminist values in (and beyond) public relations

As a central motivator for Boggs and hooks, feminist values occupy a central part of understanding their writing and activism. The feminist movement is a historical tradition based in the pursuit of knowledge creation, the inclusion of diverse thoughts, and the building of community. In public relations, feminist theory has a rich tradition of bringing undervalued or overlooked issues, challenges, and inequities to the foreground as part of communication and organizational management (e.g., Aldoory & Toth, 2021; Fitch et al., 2016; Golombisky, 2015). An ongoing project, feminism continues to inspire activism that challenges gender-based oppression.

1.4.1. Feminist theory & the historical context of knowledge creation

Feminist theory is a philosophy dedicated to the active pursuit of bettering the lives of women and other marginalized groups in a world shaped by systems of oppression (Disch & Hawkesworth, 2016; DeVault, 1999). Codified by women scholars in academia in the 1960 s and 1970 s, feminist theory pushed back against the way that academia celebrated some perspectives over others, thereby creating knowledge that was limited in scope and lacking in diversity (Hill Collins, 1986). Feminist scholars urged their colleagues and their students to set aside the idea that knowledge could only be created in sterile academic environments by those deemed as “experts,” and to instead embrace the fact that knowledge can come from lived experiences (Bannerji, 1995; Hill Collins, 1986; Hill Collins, 2015). While feminist theory is based in

philosophy, there is also a strong commitment to the pursuit of social change and reform (Spalter-Roth & Hartmann, 1996).

Scholars devoted to the pursuit of social justice are sometimes referred to as “scholar activists” due to their commitment to conducting their research for, rather than on, the populations they study (Spalter-Roth & Hartmann, 1996). Research conducted in the feminist tradition routinely blurs the lines between expert and layperson and insider and outsider, so that the influences of hierarchies, power, and privilege in society are illuminated (Maddison & Shaw, 2014). By analyzing ongoing community activism through the lens of feminist values, scholars are better “able to conceive of new forms of social existence and produce new understandings of social, cultural, and political life that have implications beyond the movement itself” (Maddison & Shaw, 2014, p. 8). Feminist scholarship has aimed to critically analyze the power structures of society, thereby inspiring and facilitating activist efforts that challenge the status quo.

Feminist activism has often grappled with the entanglement of power in social systems, even within the movement itself. Historically, the feminist tradition has been critiqued for its exclusion of women of color and queer individuals (Pruchniewska, 2016). Lorde (1984) especially problematized how white women researchers have shaped feminist theory to generalize experiences with gendered oppression (i.e., all women experience oppression in similar ways), therefore “[losing] sight of the multiple ways in which patriarchy operates” (Ghabra & Calafell, 2018, p. 48). By creating space for a variety of perspectives to be heard, feminist theorists and practitioners can better protect themselves and their communities from exclusionary biases.

1.4.2. Radical feminist thought

Feminist theorists argue that gender and racial categorizations are socially constructed identity markers that privilege some over others, and which have been used as the basis for domination and oppression (e.g., Disch & Hawkesworth, 2016). By narrowing gender and racial identity into categories, it became easier for one section of the population to assert control over others by using claims of superiority. In response to the feminist movement’s exclusionary practices, Black feminists developed a more radical, critical theoretical perspective. Scholars like Crenshaw (1991) and Hill Collins (2015) worked to build a theoretical paradigm that acknowledged the multiplicity of oppression, specifically how women of color are affected by both sexist and racist prejudice (Griffin & Chávez, 2012). Black feminist theory therefore established a “both/and” rather than “either/or” style of thinking that acknowledged that everyone has a unique lived experience (Ferguson, 2017, p. 271). Ultimately, Black feminist thought became a radical countermovement to the main feminist tradition by becoming dedicated to giving women of color the space needed to define their own realities (DeVault, 1999).

1.4.3. Feminist values in public relations

Public relations scholars have expanded the field and provided new lenses to understand and address challenges in theory and practice through the incorporation of feminist values (e.g., Aldoory & Toth, 2021; Daymon & Surma, 2012; Fitch et al., 2016; Place, 2015; Place & Vardeman-Winter, 2018; Pompper, 2013; Vardeman-Winter & Place, 2017; Golombisky, 2015). Historically, many studies entwining feminist values and public relations have focused upon what it means to be a woman in a field dominated by male leadership, while more recent scholarship has envisioned how feminist values could be embodied in public relations practice (Aldoory & Toth, 2002, 2021; Fröhlich & Peters, 2007; Tsetsura, 2010). Gender inequality in the public relations industry has been described in two notable ways: (1) at best, as a “gendered profession” where women outnumber men (Aldoory & Toth, 2002), and, (2) at worst, as a velvet ghetto that characterizes public relations as “women’s work” (Toth & Cline, 1991). Research conducted by Meng et al. (2019) notes that despite women significantly outnumbering men in the profession, there are more men in public relations

leadership roles with women filling the lower-level jobs, thus perpetuating a cycle of inequity in pay, benefits, and access to upper management roles.

There has been a recent push, however, to incorporate feminist theory even more deeply into public relations research as “the ability to offer a substantive critique of public relations practices has been shortchanged, in large part because most efforts have been directed toward developing feminist theory for rather than of public relations,” (Rakow & Nastasia, 2018, p. 354). Aldoory and Toth (2021); Fitch et al. (2016); and Golombisky (2015) are among the scholars looking to further connect feminist theory with public relations theory, examining approaches at multiple levels of analysis and moving beyond gender to incorporate intersectional critiques and lenses. Beyond this small number of studies dedicated to looking at the experience of women in the public relations industry, there are even fewer analyses of the unique experiences of women of color in public relations. This lack of diverse representation results in a “monolithic trend toward singular identities,” that fails to comprehend how women of color are perhaps “experiencing the worst marginalizations of all practitioners,” according to Varde-man-Winter and Place (2017, p. 331). Women identifying as LGBTQIA+ are even less well represented (Ciszek & Lim, 2021; Logan & Ciszek, 2022). Ultimately, by continuing to highlight how activist figures engage in public relations, the overall field gains insight into how social movements, like feminism, can use public relations to enact social change.

Combining community-oriented public relations theory, feminist public relations theory, and temporal approaches allows a clear theoretical focus on community activism. Activists benefit from community-centered perspectives (e.g., Doan & Toledano, 2018; Weaver, 2010). Feminist theory in public relations centers gender, power, and identity without shying away from activist and justice-oriented ends (e.g., Kennedy, 2016; Madden et al., 2018; Weaver, 2013). Temporal scholarship in public relations has examined the balance of short-term (Bean & Madden, 2019; Bean et al., 2015; Liu et al., 2017) and long-term (Kent, 2011) perspectives, and has begun to address activist contexts (Ciszek et al., 2021; Madden, 2015; Madden & Alt, 2021; Pal & Dutta, 2008). Taken together, these three puzzle pieces help to illuminate the work of the women community activists explored in the next section.

2. New perspectives: cases of feminist community activism

The next section presents the activism, thought, and strategic communication work of Grace Lee Boggs and bell hooks, two self-described feminists, activists, and scholar-philosophers. While their work could be understood as utilizing the strategies and tactics of public relations for activist ends, they would not have identified as public relations practitioners, a title often reserved for those working exclusively in designated public relations or strategic communication capacities (Sen, 2022). That said, activist communication and organizations have been defined within the context of public relations practice (e.g., Ciszek, 2015; Clark et al., 2022; Coombs & Holladay, 2012b; Hon, 1997; Weaver, 2010), even for those that do not self-identify as public relations practitioners. It comes down to certain qualities of how the individual fights adversity, seizes opportunities, and cultivates connections (Toledano, 2016). Some of the key qualities of those successfully practicing activist PR are the ability to continuously learn, be able to see the holistic picture, build relationships, and have strong communication skills—qualities that both Grace Lee Boggs and bell hooks embody in their respective decades-long careers. Boggs’ transition from the Civil Rights movement of the 1970s into an icon of the Asian American equality movement exemplifies her range and slow-boil activist tactics. She was open to advocating for all forms of equality, including women’s rights, and used the experience she gained to contribute back to her community with Detroit Summer, a youth program designed to get young people to put care into their Detroit community. She then used her connection with the community to create texts that continue to

communicate her activist agenda to the world, just as a PR practitioner would for a campaign. For this work, Boggs has been highlighted as a public relations pioneer by the Museum of Public Relations (2022). Similarly, hooks used her personal knowledge of the inequalities of the educational system as the basis for her call for change. Centering educational reform as the core of her argument, hooks was able to use her lived experiences to foster honesty and transparency around the power of the written word. Through her 46 books, as well as book chapters and articles, hooks was able to practice what she preached; thereby, solidifying her status as a powerful strategic communicator in pursuit of swaying the public consciousness. While there are other activists that also have had long careers in the fight for gender and racial equality, Boggs and hooks were chosen specifically because they embody community activism as a long-term fight for social justice.

Both likely would have scoffed at being called “public relations practitioners,” but their advocacy successes and enduring relevance would have been impossible without their use of conscious, purposeful strategic communication on behalf of the causes and individuals they championed. Re-envisioning them in this light presents their work as part of a rich tradition of activist public relations scholarship (e.g., Ciszek, 2015; Hon, 1997; Pompper, 2020), broadening our understanding of the origins, strategies, tactics, and boundaries of the discipline—as well as helping to reorient its history as encompassing far more than formal corporate and organizational practice. Despite their academic credentials, both Boggs and hooks saw their work as reaching audiences and having its most crucial impact far beyond the bounds of universities. Both women were driven by an urgency of concern for those in their own communities, but, through their writing, balanced specific challenges of place and more universal challenges of race, gender, and socioeconomic inequality. Both used their own experiences and perspectives as crucial grounding for their philosophy and activism. While focusing on fruitful connection points among public relations theories and these examples of community activism, the authors have sought to examine the work of Boggs and hooks on their own terms rather than imposing a traditional public relations lens onto their efforts (Weaver, 2018). Thus, these women are presented with an understanding of the tools of their activism and community organizing as public relations tools, but without labeling them “practitioners” of public relations.

2.1. Grace Lee Boggs: Rebuilding communities

Writer, activist, community leader, and “working-class philosopher” Grace Lee Boggs (1915–2015) was born in Providence, Rhode Island, but lived and organized in Detroit, the center of her advocacy efforts for more than 60 years (Baker, 2018, p. 434). She graduated from Bryn Mawr College in 1940 with a Ph.D. in philosophy but faced significant barriers to academic employment as a Chinese-American woman. As such, she turned to labor organizing, first in Chicago and then in the context of the automotive industry in Detroit in 1953 (Ward, 2016). She was a prolific author of books and articles over the course of her life—the last, *Living for Change* (2016), published when she was 95 years old. Her writing output is decidedly and consciously accessible, designed to resonate with individuals in the communities she cultivated in Detroit and similarly minded folks around the world more than academic audiences (Baker, 2018). Her organizing led her to the forefront of the Civil Rights Movement, where she collaborated with Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. and Stokely Carmichael, among others (Boggs, 2016; Ward, 2016). Over the decades, her philosophy shifted from a primary engagement with social movements and workers’ rights to centering local communities and neighborhoods.

2.1.1. Detroit as a place of reinvention

As the site of much of her life and work, the city of Detroit and its neighborhoods became an important canvas for Boggs (2011) as an organizer and a place for “practicing a new, more active, global, and

participatory concept of citizenship” (p. 72). Her vision and long-term knowledge of the community allowed her to see and explain the deeply interwoven nature of the problems it faced. Racism, sexism, and capitalism, were (and are) not wholly separate, but intertwined challenges, which she approached with a “critical self-reflexivity” (Baker, 2018, p. 440) that led to an evolution in her thought and advocacy over time. She sought solace and direction in finding local answers, creating local resources, and building local resilience. Her work made (and continues to make) individual communities in Detroit stronger and the individuals within them more tightly connected with each other—as well as less dependent on global structures of predatory capitalism, resource extraction, and exploitation (Boggs, 2009, 2011, 2016). Where others saw devastation in the economic collapse and eventual bankruptcy of the city of Detroit, Boggs saw the opportunity for revolution, reinvention, and rebirth through feminist activism and organizing:

In Detroit we are engaged in this long and beautiful struggle for a new world because we have learned through our own experience that just changing the color of those in political power was not enough to stem the devastation of our city resulting from deindustrialization. (Boggs, 2011, p. 74)

These efforts took many forms that worked to reimagine physical spaces and places within the city as well as to build relationships across generations. For example, her Detroit Summer program embodied these values by helping high school students to understand and value their own communities through doing a variety of neighborhood-centered projects (such as cultivating community gardens, cleaning up vacant lots, renovating abandoned homes, and creating murals). She understood this work as a tangible, visible investment that students were able to make in building communities in which they wanted to live. Detroit Summer also served to connect student volunteers with older project leaders (often community elders) to build intergenerational social capital and a long-term vision of neighborhood purpose (Boggs, 2000, 2011). These generations (including Southern-born elders, factory workers, veteran activists/organizers, urban youth) provided a richness of experience and perspective to serve as a foundation for reinvestment, community investment, and self-governance.

2.1.2. Women as community leaders

Early on in her community activism, Boggs realized that women were particularly well positioned to lead her community-centered revolutionary movement. As part of her own evolution, Boggs saw that top-down hierarchies of many large-scale social movements also reproduced the patriarchal cultures minimized the local knowledge and perspectives crucial to transformation: “Since discovering that the personal is political, women activists have been abandoning the charismatic male, vertical, and vanguard party leadership patterns of the 1960 s and creating more participatory, empowering, and horizontal kinds of leadership” (Boggs, 2011, p. 173). For Boggs, this horizontality allowed for more locally situated solutions to locally situated challenges—women as central nodes in the network constituting a community’s fabric and social capital, and as the best positioned to understand how distinct challenges might be addressed.

Part of the foundational shift, for Boggs, returned to the re-valuing of different types of

labor—of understanding that traditionally “women’s” work often was the most important work: What actually holds the very fabric of our society together are local activities that are not done for money: household activities such as raising children and cooking; barter activities like trading services with friends or neighbors; and cooperative enterprises based on common ownership and control. (p. 170)

Thus, in centering and empowering women as leaders, and valuing their crucial community contributions, Boggs reminds us that we do not need to wait for political parties, charismatic orators, or the next vibrant

social movement to make a community impact. Each of us is already part of a community and has unique knowledge that can be the source of powerful advocacy and transformation (Boggs, 2016; Ward, 2016).

2.1.3. Institutional and temporal investment

Boggs positioned her work as a long-term investment in communities. Her emphasis on topics such as education and intergenerational connectivity center a long-term approach to the pressing issues faced by Detroit’s neighborhoods. While she does not dispute the immediate need to address these issues for individuals in her communities, she understands that genuine solutions are long-term and revolutionary rather than short term:

Living at the margins of the postindustrial capitalist order, we in Detroit are faced with a stark choice of how to devote ourselves to struggle. Should we strain to squeeze the last drops of life out of a failing, deteriorating, and unjust system? Or should we instead devote our creative and collective energies toward envisioning and building a radically different form of living? (Boggs, 2011, p. 134)

Truly centering deindustrialization means consideration of much longer-term goals and objectives than many activists address. It prompts a reevaluation of our approach to what a successful and prosperous community might be, and how “wealth” is defined. For Boggs, it meant a focus on resilience and community self-reliance for the long-term: “Instead of investing our hopes in GM, Ford, and Chrysler and becoming increasingly alienated from the Earth, we needed to invest in, work with, and rely on each other” (p. 110).

2.1.4. Transformative community education

Boggs bemoans the factory model of education practiced by many public and private schools, emphasizing standardized tests, rote memorization, and authority over exploration (Boggs, 1970, 2011, 2016). She specifically connects the origins of public school in the U.S. to the needs of a growing capitalist society and its evolution (amid segregated housing practices in many major cities) as another layer of racial discrimination and unequally allocated resources (Boggs, 1970). But it has the potential to be a crucial part of “two-sided transformation”—her understanding that, to change our institutions, we must also change ourselves (p. 90). Thus, education plays a central role in Boggs’s understanding of revolution and community building. Rather than focus on theory, she centered her advocacy on transformative action—putting students to work in their own communities. “Love of place” is created through meaningful contributions and connections (p. 157). Thus, embedding schools in communities develops practical partnerships and skills (such as volunteer work to plant and tend community gardens). It helps to connect students with community leaders, build intergenerational bonds, and understand the value of meaningful work (Baker, 2018; Ward, 2016). In these ways, education could serve not only to provide practical knowledge and place-based social capital, but to help create a sense of a beloved community for students (Boggs, 2004).

2.2. bell hooks: a pillar of community

Writer, teacher, and community activist, bell hooks (born Gloria Jean Watkins, 1952–2021) is known for her cultural criticism and life-long dedication to inspiring social change. Born in Kentucky to a working-class family, hooks grew up in a segregated neighborhood where she was surrounded by the racial and sexist prejudices she grew to push back against (hooks, 2009). Over her decades-long career, hooks published over 40 books and scholarly articles on a range of topics, such as intersectionality, the power of patriarchy, pedagogy, feminist theory and practice, and community creation through education. Regarding this last subject, hooks crafted her book, *Teaching Community: A Pedagogy of Hope* (2003), to provide “practical wisdom about what we do and can continue to do to make the classroom a place that is life-sustaining

and mind-expanding, a place of liberating mutuality where teacher and student together work in partnership” (xv). Intertwined throughout the collection of essays is a testament of hope—hope that by implementing a “collective awareness of the spirit of community” in the classroom, wider society will follow suit to build and sustain a healthier, more inclusive form of community (xv). Ultimately, hooks constructed a personal form of strategic communication that inspires others to participate in her vision for community activism.

2.2.1. Integrating feminist theory with practice

Among the greatest contributions that hooks made to the feminist movement were her writings discussing how the interlocking oppressions associated with race and gender culminate into unique lived experiences for Black women. In *Ain't I a Woman? Black Women and Feminism* (1981), hooks' critical analysis looked at how the lineage of slavery continues to exploit and abuse women of color in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, thereby embodying the ideas of intersectionality theory before the term was codified by Crenshaw in 1989. According to Crenshaw in an interview for *The New York Times*, hooks' work “gave theoretical ballast to political organizing that was happening on the ground” by identifying the double-bind Black women experienced in society (Schussler, 2021, para. 8). hooks' believed that a combination of theory and practice was the best way to measure the success of the feminist movement, most specifically through the fostering of community. hooks was able to incorporate the feminist value of inclusivity in her pedagogical teachings (2003, p. xi) by committing to “write theory that would speak directly to an inclusive audience,” most specifically, their community (2003, xi-xii).

2.2.2. Activism in the classroom

For hooks, the teaching of community creates the potential for significant societal reform. The classroom has the power to provide counternarratives to the mainstream misconceptions of post-feminism and post-racism—the ideas that modern society has grown beyond the need for reckoning with the issues of gender and racial inequality. Scholar activists like hooks believe that knowledge production should not be isolated to the expert few, rather the practice should be expanded to all those in society so that the theory “can serve to expand all our communities of resistance so that they are not just composed of college teachers, students, or well-educated politicians” (hooks, 2003, p. xii). To practice what she preached, hooks left a post in academia in 1988 to turn her efforts to the community building: by visiting public schools, writing books, and holding pedagogical courses for professors and students, hooks was able to fulfill her commitment to changing the classroom into a space of innovation rather than stagnation.

2.2.3. Community through democratic education

Using the idea of “democratic education,” a theoretical view of education where the needs of the learner, the community, and society are best met through the development of reflective individuals who can collaborate, problem-solve, and remain creative and flexible in their thinking, hooks advocated for a blurring of lines between academia and the “real” world (hooks, 2003, p. 41). In her experience as a professor, she was often met with the sentiment that learning was to be confined to the “institutionalized classroom,” and that the skills practiced in school had no relevance to everyday life (p. 41)—much like how public relations courses too often focus on practice rather than how the industry could better serve the broader community. So, hooks and other proponents of the democratic classroom model (e.g., Paulo Freire, Yaacov Hecht) sought to “challenge themselves to teach beyond [this limited view of] the classroom setting, to move into the world sharing knowledge, learn a diversity of styles to convey information” (p. 43). hooks aimed to change this perception by instead advocating for a pedagogical model where teachers and students work together in a democratic collaboration to make learning more accessible and inclusive. In her version of democratic education, hooks relies on the simple art of

conversation as the ideal way to “affir[m] to listeners that learning can take place in varied time frames (we can share and learn a lot in 5 min) and that knowledge can be shared in diverse modes of speech” (p. 44). hooks believed that the classroom should be a space where individuals can craft a critical awareness of the systems of power operating in a society, therefore empowering them to participate in a “commitment to end domination” (p. 45). Democratic education aims to not only erase the barrier between the class space and the “real” world, but it also takes aim at the expert/layperson dichotomy, as well as the teacher/student power structure. To address how many marginalized students continue to be shamed for their views and/or experiences through guised attempts at “maintaining imperialist white-supremacist patriarchal hegemony in the academic world” (p. 102), hooks urged educators to “[enact] a politics of affirmation” where all voices are respected and “deemed worthy” (p. 103). Strategically, hooks focused on radically changing the classroom to enact social change on a wider scale. By training teachers to incorporate feminist and community values into their work, the future generations would learn to work together, rather than against each other.

2.2.4. Community, longing, and “homeplace”

Community does not just refer to physical locations, but instead encompasses the humanity of a place (hooks, 2009). In the essay *Homeplace (a site of resistance)* (1990/2001), hooks discussed the importance of her geographic identity as a scholar activist. For hooks, the ideal of home represented not only safety, but also was a source for people of color to “nurtur[e] [their] souls” (p. 383). Be it in the segregated neighborhoods of the South or in subtle racial microaggressions perpetuated by antiracist propaganda, hooks believed that a return to home, to community, was the solution for anguish in the face of social injustice (p. 384). Homeplace is a community, a group of like-minded people centered around a shared cause. hooks used the metaphor of homeplace to highlight the historical oppression of Black people, as well as the historical tradition of Black resistance through community. Overall, the essay by hooks in 1990 foreshadowed hooks' choice to leave her post at Yale University to teach at a university not far from the neighborhood where she grew up. Her time at Kentucky's Berea College, where she taught from 2004 until her death in 2021, exemplifies hooks' weariness with the bureaucracy of academia (amongst other institutions). At the end of her life, hooks took her own advice and turned to the familiarity of her community.

3. Discussion: Framing ongoing community activism

The next section provides theoretical and practical implications and synthesis of the work and thought of Boggs and hooks, as well as presenting the framework of ongoing community activism for activist, community-centered public relations.

3.1. Theoretical & practical implications

Scholarship on activism in public relations has positioned advocates and practitioners in new roles (Holtzhausen, 2000, 2013), centered the work of social movements (Edrington & Lee, 2018; Sommerfeldt & Xu, 2014; Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2017; You & Hon, 2019), and added important and generative historical public relations stories to scholarship (Hill, 2016; Hon, 1997; Pompper, 2020). This essay revisits the concepts of community and community building in public relations (e.g., Hallahan, 2004; Kruckeberg & Starck, 1988; Shen & Jiang, 2022; Vujnovic et al., 2021; Williams & Sommerfeldt, 2021; Witherow, 2020), re-emphasizing and operationalizing (1) the role of community activism in community building, and (2) centering the importance of time and timing—both short-term (Madden, 2015) and long-term (Kent, 2011; O'Neil, 2009)—in community activism. To capture the centrality of temporality, this paper introduces a novel framework: *Ongoing Community Activism*. Grounded in our analysis of Boggs's and hooks's

conceptions of activism, community, and temporality, it examines advocacy, community, education, and feminism as central, generative themes (Table 1).

By analyzing the work of scholar-philosophers and scholar activists like Boggs and hooks, public relations theory can better grasp the complexities of community activism. Applying feminist theory to public relations research (Daymon & Surma, 2012; Golombisky, 2015; Grunig et al., 2000; Place, 2015; Place & Vardeman-Winter, 2018; Pompper, 2013; Vardeman-Winter & Place, 2017) provides a lens to focus on the lived experiences of two activists of color who, in advocacy sustained over decades, used concepts of place, identity, education, and home in pursuit of the betterment of their communities (Boggs, 2011; Boggs, 2016; hooks, 2003; hooks, 1990/2001, 2009). The inclusion of the principles of feminist theory, such as the critique of knowledge (DeVault, 1999), the inclusion of varied lived experiences (Bannerji, 1995; Hill Collins, 1986, 2015; Griffin & Chávez, 2012; Ferguson, 2017), the critical analysis of power structures (Maddison & Shaw, 2014), and the active goal of social justice (Spalter-Roth & Hartmann, 1996), into public relations research not only deepens the study of activists, but should also be used as a building block for making the public relations discipline and the cumulative efforts of strategic communicators more equitable for all (Aldoory & Toth, 2021).

Timing and temporality has been of concern at both ends of the public relations research spectrum: The immediate need to respond to natural disasters and crises (e.g., Bean et al., 2015; Liu et al., 2017; Madden, 2015) or be engaged and present for genuine dialogue (e.g., Kent & Taylor, 2002; Taylor & Kent, 2014) in contrast to the call for a long-term understanding of the implications of strategic communication practices (Kent, 2011; O'Neil, 2009). In community activism, and in the work of Boggs and hooks, there is a visible need to understand both ends of this spectrum simultaneously: To advocate for urgent, pressing community needs, as well as to realize the vital role of long-term community building efforts. hooks (2009) describes an ongoing pull and inescapability of homeplace, while Boggs (2011, 2016), over the course of her long life, evolves to prioritize the decades-long processes of cultivating community investment, pride, and self-reliance as central to

her activism. In a sense, for her, the ongoing commitment to those processes is the center of transformative community activism and building beloved communities (Baker, 2018). It is certainly a shift for public relations and activism to think in decades-long outcomes or epochal time, rather than short-term objectives, strategies, and tactics—but bringing these narratives of community activism to the fore showcases the value and impact of this shift in perspective (McLean et al., 2021).

This project makes contributions to public relations history by positioning Boggs and hooks' efforts as valuable examples of strategic communication, not as an activist problem to be solved (Grunig, 1992; Myers, 2020). In doing so, it expands the scope of who and what can be identified as part of public relations history (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2012b; Fitch & L'Etang, 2017; L'Etang, 2014), as well as the connection points between activism, communication, and social networks (e.g., Bennett & Segerberg, 2012; Saffer, 2019). In this way, community activism, over time, can play a substantial role in community building (Hallahan, 2004; Moscato, 2018; Weaver, 2010)—supporting the civil society (e.g., Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010) and social capital (Saffer, 2016; Taylor, 2011, 2018) outcomes and contributions of public relations as part of deliberative societies (Edwards, 2016) and community networks (Yang & Taylor, 2015). It also points toward connections between the enactment of community activism and the cultivation of community resilience in public relations (Bean et al., 2015; Dharmasena et al., 2020; Liu et al., 2017). This contributes to a more honest, inclusive, and holistic history of those doing public relations work beyond the bounds of formal organizations (e.g., Fitch & L'Etang, 2017; Lamme & Russell, 2009; Pompper, 2020; Russell & Lamme, 2016) and representing a wider variety of identities (Pompper & Ertem-Eray, 2021), without conflating community-oriented work with corporate or professional public relations (Weaver, 2018).

Community making is an essential part of all grassroots activism—specifically the creation of a feeling of home. Home refers to a metaphorical connection between individuals that is enduring and works to make life better for all members (hooks, 1990/2001, 2009). Cultivating home/homeplace demonstrates the need for involvement, nurturing,

Table 1
Ongoing community activism in public relations.

Theme	Definition	Temporal Example	Sources
Community: Making Communities “Home”	“Home” is inescapable—a kind of community built through ongoing engagement, shared understanding, deep commitment, and pride in place.	Genuine community building requires long-term investment and commitment to place, as well as an interpersonal sense of welcoming (hooks, 1990/2001) and individual ownership (Boggs, 2011).	Capizzo & Madden, 2022; Ghabra & Calafell, 2018; Hallahan, 2004; Kruckeberg & Starck, 1988; Spalter-Roth & Hartmann, 1996; Vujanovic et al., 2021
Feminism: Finding Leaders Within	Community activism should be guided by feminist values of inclusion, critique of power, and the pursuit of social justice. The importance of individual standpoints and experiences, especially those of marginalized groups, should be celebrated.	Activists should not wait for the “right” leaders to emerge, they already have the skills, talent, and passion—women are often perfectly positioned for community leadership (Boggs, 2011, 2016). Feminist theory can act as a guide for activists to make sure that their efforts are equitable and based in the pursuit of social reform (hooks, 2003).	Aldoory & Toth, 2021; Bannerji, 1995; Crenshaw, 1991; Disch & Hawkesworth, 2016; Ferguson, 2017; Hill Collins, 1986; Hill Collins, 2015; Lorde, 1984; Pruchniewska, 2016; Madden & Alt, 2021; Madden et al., 2018; Rakow & Nastasia, 2018; Vardeman-Winter & Place, 2017
Advocacy: Horizontal, Intersectional, and Inclusive	Sustainable grassroots advocacy must be deeply centered on the needs of specific, diverse geographic communities, which can only be achieved through a degree of decentralization and local autonomy. Tactics must be accessible and not exclude unnecessarily.	Grassroots ways of knowing and organizing support differentiated, localized, and sustainable/ongoing advocacy (Boggs, 2011) that can harness commonalities (and overcome differences) within geographic communities (hooks, 2009). Plain language is always preferred when creating activist materials accessible to the public (hooks, 2003).	Bennett & Segerberg, 2012; Ciszek, 2015; Ciszek, Mocarski, Price, et al., 2021; Coombs & Holladay, 2012a; Coombs & Holladay, 2012b; Sommerfeldt & Taylor, 2011; Vardeman & Sebesta, 2020
Education: Active and Place-based	The ongoing process of education creates myriad opportunities to connect individuals with each other (across generations) and build relationships and increase social connectivity: Both interpersonally and between individuals and places.	Transformational education need not be theoretical—in fact, it is through concrete, practical, and literal community building that individuals (of all ages) come to see themselves as part of communities (Boggs, 2011). Education should act as a space for togetherness—the classroom should mold future members of a community based on the shared goal of a better future (hooks, 2003).	DeVault, 1999; Griffin & Chávez, 2012; Saffer, 2019; Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010

and organizing that serve as crucial community-building tasks (Hallahan, 2004). Both Boggs and hooks crafted their activism to play the “long game.” Their dedication to reforming education, to investing in young people, and to their valuing of conversation as the building block for getting people involved all exhibit how Boggs and hooks believed that investing time and resources into a community over time would result in more significant, longer-lasting reform (hooks, 2003).

Both Boggs and hooks applied philosophy propagated in the feminist movement, especially the valuing of individual experiences and knowledge creation (hooks, 2003). The inclusion of feminist ideals into their work led both activists to shed the conventions of society and live their lives by turning philosophies of change into practice. Hooks left her tenured job at Yale University to devote herself to teaching others how to improve the world around them. Boggs (2016) chose to dedicate her efforts to building intergenerational social capital and cultivating personal community investment. Both activists dedicated themselves to problematizing power structures while valuing individual lived experiences. Both Boggs and hooks worked towards intersectional activism in the causes they championed and in the activist movements themselves (Vardeman & Sebesta, 2020). As a Black woman, hooks frequently challenged the centering of white experiences in the feminist movement (hooks, 2003). She specifically highlighted how ignoring the implications of racism for women of color limits everyone’s understanding of oppression. Similarly, as an Asian woman living in Detroit, Boggs (2011, 2016) witnessed first-hand the abandonment of local, predominately Black, communities by political leaders—necessitating the long-term investment on community self-reliance, self-governance, and cultivation of pride.

Practically, the lens of ongoing community activism sheds light on the work of issues management, both from corporate perspectives (Coombs & Holladay, 2018; McKasy & Zulli, 2021; Waymer & Heath, 2019) and activist perspectives (Derville, 2005; Gudkova & Sarikakis, 2018; Madden, 2019; Smith & Ferguson, 2010; Woods, 2019). All types of organizations should incorporate understandings of (1) community and homeplace as well as (2) temporality more deeply into their engagement in issue discourses. Activist organizations and individual activists should recognize their full potential as community builders through social movements (Hon, 1997; McCarthy & Zald, 1977; Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2017) as well as understand the importance and value of cultivating community engagement and connection over time (Boggs, 2016; hooks, 2009). Activist organizations and community advocates must be fully cognizant of the balance between short-term needs of their supporters, members, and stakeholders, and the long-term policy outcomes and societal changes they seek. Both Boggs and hooks lived in this tension rather than avoiding it—their work built and embraced the slow cultivation of community-building over years or decades while remaining responsive and engaged to the immediate concerns of community members (Baker, 2018; Schuessler, 2021). As Boggs noted, this approach created the potential for two-sided transformation by addressing both the human, individual potential for change as well as the community and institutional evolution (Boggs, 2011). It reminds nonprofits and community organizers to see their communication efforts as having positive potential beyond their policy-oriented ends, but also through the processes and relationship cultivation needed to bring folks together toward advocacy. Future scholars would benefit from examining activism and temporality with additional nuance, and applying rhetorical theories such as Kairos (e.g., Bean & Madden, 2019; Scott, 2006; Sullivan, 1992; Trapani & Maldonado, 2018) that may further connect community, temporality, communicative opportunity, and even risk inherent in this type of work.

Also important, from an activist public relations perspective, was the conscious and sustained choice of both women to embrace a plain-spoken approach to their writing. Despite the potential for backlash and exclusion from academic circles (Boggs, 2011, 2016; hooks, 2009; Ward, 2016), the steadfast dedication to accessible language distinguishes Boggs and hooks from many activist academics and has, in part,

led to their enduring appeal with activists and broadly in society (Baker, 2018; Boggs, 2011, 2016; hooks, 2003, 2009; Schuessler, 2021; Ward, 2016). Part of this approach came from the emphasis of centering their own experiences, and the experiences of women of color as part of their work—an important lesson for activists aspiring to intersectional representation (Vardeman & Sebesta, 2020).

4. Conclusion

Issues are cyclical (Coombs & Holladay, 2018), but communities are enduring (Hallahan, 2004; Kruckeberg & Starck, 1988). The stories, strategies, and legacies of Grace Lee Boggs and bell hooks provide richness to the cannon of public relations history, but also a generative set of principles and frameworks to enlighten public relations theory, particularly in regard to activism and community building. Gender matters—both in creating inclusive social movements and in developing effective grassroots leadership. These narratives of community activism allow us to tease out the temporal extremes of public relations engagement: From immediate activist responses to decades-long neighborhood projects. Physical space and place matters—both as a strategic variable and a potential resource or reservoir for the energy and commitment needed to make constructive change in organizations, neighborhoods, or societies. As evidenced in these stories and histories, communication and public relations is at the center of cultivating such change. As they also demonstrate, the value of public relations and community building in the context of community activism goes beyond transforming public opinion, public policy, and even communities themselves, but it comes from the actions, meanings, and dialogs that help transform individuals.

Conflicts of Interest

None.

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